

Personal Statement

While studying for my A-levels I took part in the Cyber Discovery challenge funded by the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport and completed an ethical hacking course at Cardiff University with PWC. As a result of this work, I realised that this sector will become increasingly important to individuals, companies and our country due to the rapid growth of the “Internet of Things” and our reliance on technology and the potentially devastating implications of failing to protect our data and systems. Cyber Security was an obvious career choice as it combines the subjects I love with a rewarding job in a growing industry. I chose to study Cyber Security at the University of Warwick as the course is certified by the National Cyber Security Centre at GCHQ. Based on the experience that I have gained from my course I am interested in progressing my career in cyber security and computing.

Core Skills

Programming languages:	Software:	Other:
- Python - C - SQL - Bash - Powershell - HTML	- PostgreSQL/MYSQL - Burp Suite - Linux/Windows - Wireshark - Mircosoft Office - VMware/Virtual Box	- Confidence in public speaking - UML Design - Data modeling - Normalisation/Relational databases - Full Clean UK Driving License

University of Warwick - Cyber Security, BSc (Hons)

2020-2023

Grade: First Class

First Year	- Software Development and Security - Cyber Systems Architecture and Organisation - Discrete Structures for Cyber Security	- Networks, Communication and Cyber Defence - Operating Systems in the Cyber Context - Information Risk Management
Second Year	- The Cyber Context of Software Engineering - Programming Languages for Cyber Security - Human Behaviour in Cyber Systems	- Implementing Secure Systems - Information Management - Information Risk and Security Management
Third Year	- Low-level Tools and Techniques for Cyber Security - Data Science, Algorithms and Complexity in the Cyber Context	- Operational Security Management - Cyber Security Incident Management - Individual Project - Detecting Phishing Attacks Using Natural Language Processing

Key Course Experience

The Cyber Context of Software Engineering – To gain a first in this module I oversaw a nine-month team effort to design and develop a Python-based space station simulator. As the primary security tester for every design change, it was my responsibility to make sure threat modelling is utilised to identify threats, create defences, support appropriate risk responses and test security. I confirmed that input and output specifications outline exactly how to handle and process data following its type, content and any applicable laws, regulations and policies and verify all incoming and outgoing connections were encrypted using TLS.

Information Management – I created and secured a PostgreSQL database storing data for a theoretical Kennel Company. I achieved a first in this module by abiding by GDPR, PCI-DSS and other security best practices including client authentication control, Data Encryption (on connection SSL and at rest) and Auditing/Logging.

Information Risk and Security Management – This module included a section on developing a security policy framework that was compliant with UK government regulations. I researched and put into practice security controls, risk management, planning for the execution of policies, incident prevention, response and management, as well as access control/physical security, to achieve a first.

A-levels

Mathematics - A

Chemistry - A

Computer Science – A*

AS – Levels

Mathematics AS level – A

Chemistry AS level – A

Computer Science AS level – B

Business Studies AS level– B

GCSE

14 GCSEs - 3 A*, 2 A, 8 B, 1 C

Key Personal Achievements

- I undertook a Cyber Discovery challenge funded by the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport. This consisted of solving 14 cybersecurity-related problems. After completing all 14 questions I was invited to the next stage of the process called Cyberstart Essentials.
- I completed an ethical hacking course at Cardiff University with PWC in November 2019 to learn more about Cyber Security.
- I won an international competition Veracode as part of the Warwick University team, winning my university £10,000 in prize money. <https://www.veracode.com/press-release/university-warwick-wins-veracodes-first-ever-hacker-games>
- I've competed in Hackthebox challenges and earned the title of Pro Hacker.
- I have an aptitude to learn new concepts quickly and efficiently and am willing to devote my personal time to gain new skills; for example, I taught myself many tricky card routines that have left everyone I have performed in front of mesmerised and from sleight of hand to learning sentences and vocabulary in German, Arabic and Slovak and even learning to do the Rubik's cube in under 30 seconds within a few weeks.
- I am an accomplished athlete competing across a range of sports representing my school and country. I gained a sports scholarship at the University of Warwick for climbing. My most extraordinary achievements are in my beloved sport, climbing. I started climbing at the age of 7 and fell in love with the sport as it combines strength, technique and problem-solving. I completed all levels in the National Indoor Climbing Award Scheme where I learned the importance of teamwork, communication and trust with partners to mitigate the risk of this potentially dangerous sport. I have competed in and was placed 1st in many regional and national competitions.
- I represented Wales at the final of the British youth climbing series in Scotland. It is through competitions that I learned how to deal with immense stress and disappointment as well as enjoyment from competitions where the slightest mistakes can make the difference between success and failure. This required tremendous amounts of training, dedication and determination to become a top-tier athlete in a very demanding sport. I take my fitness very seriously while remembering to have fun as well.
- GitHub: <https://github.com/bensmithyx>